Does Proximity Matter?
Terrorism Salience Following the 2015 Paris Attacks

Chiara Pizzetti

Supervisor: Chiar.mo Prof. Nicola Pontarollo
Co-supervisor: Chiar.mo Prof. Giovanni Maria Abbiati

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Università di Brescia

Why Study Terrorism Salience? The French Case

- Terrorism is a rare event, but fear and concern far exceed the objective risk
  - A policy priority: shapes security policy and electoral behavior
- Attention is limited: terrorism can act as a **"killer issue"**
- **Terrorism salience**: the extent to which citizens identify terrorism as one of the most important problems facing their country
- France: a particularly relevant case
  - Previous history of terrorism
  - Charlie Hebdo, January 2015
  - November 2015: deadliest attacks on French soil since WWII

What the Literature Says: Proximity Effects

Direct and indirect effects: attacks affect the target country and, possibly, others, but the evidence is mixed

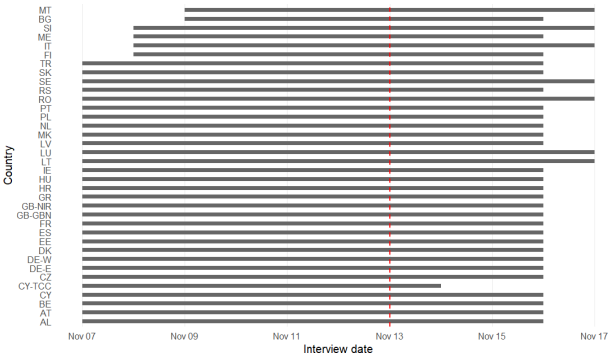
- **Nussio et al. (2021)**: Paris attacks raise attention to terrorism in France and, less, in the rest of Europe
- **Böhmelt et al. (2020)**: effects spread more to neighboring countries (migration concern)
- **Nussio et al. (2019)**: no proximity effect (migration attitudes)
- **Criado (2017)**: previous experience of terrorism shapes how new attacks are interpreted

Research Question and Contribution

- **Research question**: does proximity to a terrorist attack, geographical or experiential, condition its effect on terrorism salience?
- **Contribution**
  - Neighboring countries as an intermediate group
  - Previous exposure to terrorism as a second dimension of proximity
- **Expectations**
  - Geography: France $>$ Neighbors $>$ Rest of Europe
  - Experience: Previous Exposure $>$ Neighbors

The Event and The Data

- **Event**: 13 November 2015
  - Coordinated attacks in Paris and Saint-Denis
  - 130 people killed
- **Fieldwork**: 7–17 November
  - Attacks in the middle of the survey
- **Outcome**: Terrorism Salience
  - $Y = 1$ if terrorism is among the two most important issues, 0 otherwise



Fieldwork period by country. Red line: 13 November

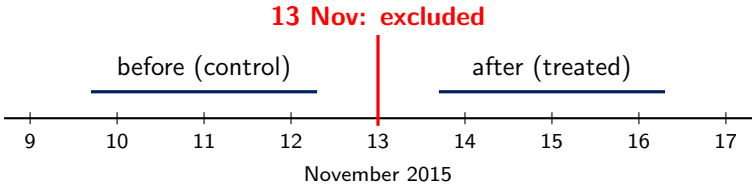
Data: Standard Eurobarometer 84.3 (EU's official public opinion survey)

Why a UESD?

Unexpected Event during Survey Design (UESD)

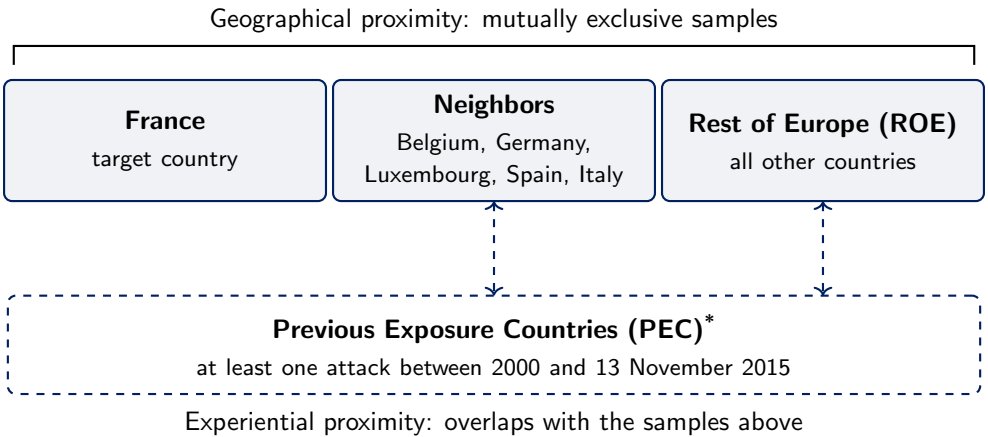
- **Idea**: compare respondents interviewed before and after the attacks, within the same survey
- **Key assumption**: interview timing is as good as random
- **Why it fits here**
  - Attacks cannot be manipulated
  - The attacks occurred during the Eurobarometer fieldwork
  - Unrelated trends are unlikely to drive the results

Treatment Assignment and Control Variables



- **Treatment**: interviewed after the attacks
  - 3 days after vs. 3 days before
  - 13 November excluded: those respondents cannot be classified
- **Control Variables**: age, gender, rural residence, occupation

The Four Samples



* Spain, the United Kingdom, Germany, Belgium, Bulgaria, Denmark, the Netherlands

Assumptions and Entropy Balancing

- **Excludability**: timing affects the outcome only through the attacks, not through other events
- **Ignorability**: people interviewed before and after are comparable
  - Balance tests on the controls
  - France, Neighbors: balanced
  - ROE, PEC: some imbalances
- **Entropy balancing**: reweights the control group to match the treated
  - Weights are used in the estimation

Empirical Strategy

Logit Model

$$\Pr(Y_i = 1 \mid \text{Treatment}_i, X_i) = \Lambda\left(\beta_0 + \beta_1 \,\text{Treatment}_i + X_i'\gamma\right) \tag{1}$$

Odds Ratio

$$OR_{\text{Treatment}} = \exp(\beta_1) \tag{2}$$

Average Marginal Effect (AME)

$$AME_{\text{Treatment}} = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}\left[\Lambda(\beta_0 + \beta_1 + X_i'\gamma) - \Lambda(\beta_0 + X_i'\gamma)\right] \tag{3}$$

France, Neighbors: standard logit. ROE, PEC: logit with entropy balancing weights.

Results and Discussion: The French Case

Sample	Logit coefficient	Odds ratio	AME (pp)
France	**1.92*** **	**6.82*** **	**37.60*** **
Neighbors	0.64***	1.90***	5.20***
ROE	0.75***	2.12***	5.50***
PEC	1.01***	2.75***	9.40***

Notes: logit models with controls; ROE and PEC use entropy balancing weights.
*** $p < 0.01$.

Estimates of the Effect of the Paris Attacks on Terrorism Salience

Why is the effect in France so large?

- **Reactivated issue**: Charlie Hebdo (January 2015)
- **Existing frame**: terrorism, national security and immigration

Results and Discussion: Two Dimensions of Proximity

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Estimates of the Effect of the Paris Attacks on Terrorism Salience

- **Geographical proximity**: no gradient, Neighbors ≈ ROE
  - May matter for concrete concerns
- **Experiential proximity**: stronger effect in PEC
  - Ready interpretive frame, frame activation, recall and sensitization
- Distinct, outcome-specific mechanisms

Conclusions

- **Main findings**
  - In France the attacks reshaped the public agenda
  - No geographical gradient across Europe
  - Previous exposure matters
- **Limitations**
  - A single, exceptional event
  - Short window: immediate reaction only
- **Future research**
  - More attacks
  - Longer time horizons

Thank you!

Questions and comments are welcome.

Chiara Pizzetti



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